Whose Question Is It?

What to ask the discharge planner, the nurse, the pharmacist and the therapist before your husband's care changes.

Some of what's on your mind is a phone call to a cousin. Some of it is a question for the nurse, the pharmacist or the therapist, and it was never yours to settle. This page sorts the second kind by who can answer.

Bring the page with you, read the questions out as they're written, and put the answer on the lines underneath. Nothing here answers a question or says which one comes first. That depends on your husband, and the people below are the ones who know his situation.

The discharge planner, social worker or care coordinator

Whoever is arranging the change. The title varies from place to place, and it may be a nurse or another member of staff.

1. During which parts of the day and night do you expect my husband to need someone with him, and what for?

2. Will he need help at night, and if he does, how will I get enough sleep?

3. Here are the hours our family has covered and the hours still open. Can we go over them together before the arrangement changes?

4. Here is what I can do myself, and what I can't keep up for long. Can the plan be looked at again with that in mind?

5. Will someone come to see the place he's going to and tell us whether anything there needs attention?

6. For each concern on our list, who on the care team is following up, and how will we hear back?

7. Can we have his care instructions in writing, and the names and numbers to call with questions, including nights and weekends?

The nurse

1. What help does the staff give him overnight where he is now?

2. We've written down a few things about how much he drinks, continence and his skin. Who should look at them?

The pharmacist or the prescriber

1. Is this list of everything he takes complete and current: prescriptions, over-the-counter items, vitamins and supplements?

2. Here is what we've noticed about how he manages his medications from day to day. Can you review it with us?

The therapist, if one is involved

1. Here is what we've seen when he stands up, walks and uses the stairs, and any falls. Which of it do you want to look at?

The doctor

1. Which of the concerns we've written down do you want to review before the arrangement changes?

2. Once it has changed, is there anything you want us to watch for, and who do we tell if we see it?

Your care consultant

Someone who looks for gaps in caregiver coverage, and records health concerns for the care team instead of writing care instructions.

1. Here is our page of covered hours, open hours and open questions. What is missing from it that you would want to see?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or put them in order of importance. If one of them is weighing on you, say so to the person you're asking, and ask it first.

Ready for the next step?

You know which questions to bring, and to whom. As the answers come in, the care interview gives them somewhere to go: it walks you through your husband's situation area by area and turns what you know into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Several of these questions follow ones that Medicare's discharge checklist, the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide and the CDC's brochure for family caregivers suggest families ask. The sorting by who can answer is ours.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Family Caregivers: Protect Your Loved Ones from Falling (STEADI brochure, 2018)

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.